Health: kind words and advice

TASK 1

How are you feeling?

In pairs: how many health problems do you know in English? Write them. Which are serious, and which are not?

NOT SERIOUS	SERIOUS

TASK 2

What's the problem?

Read the six conversations. **Choose** the problem for each one.

a hangover · a sprained ankle · food poisoning · toothache · sunburn · a sore throat

Adapted from: Gardner, N. 'Health and illness', a lesson plan on *English Lesson Planner*. Conversations, cards and letter written for this lesson by Ramy Sakr for Connect Lite (2026).

TASK 3

Six conversations

Choose the problem. Then **complete** the advice with a word from the box.

rest · drink · put · see · taking · call

A **Omar:** Why are you walking like that?
Lena: I twisted my foot playing football yesterday and now it's really swollen.
Omar: Oh, you poor thing. You should _____ it on a cushion and put some ice on it.

B **Kai:** You look terrible this morning.
Mia: It was Sam's birthday. I don't remember getting home, and my head is killing me.
Kai: Well, it serves you right! Why don't you _____ lots of water?

C **Ana:** Your face is bright red!
Tom: I fell asleep on the beach for three hours. It really hurts.
Ana: That must be awful. If I were you, I'd _____ some after-sun cream on it.

D **Ravi:** Are you OK? You've hardly eaten anything.
Noor: I can't chew on this side. It's been hurting for a week.
Ravi: Oh dear. You ought to _____ the dentist today.

E **Hana:** Sorry? I can't hear you.
Leo: I've lost my voice. I was shouting at the match all night.
Hana: Well, you've only got yourself to blame! Have you tried _____ honey and lemon?

F **Sofia:** Where were you yesterday?
Ben: I was ill all night after that seafood restaurant. I couldn't stop being sick.
Sofia: Oh no, that must have been horrible. You'd better _____ the restaurant.

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TASK 4

Kind or not?

Mark each sentence S (sympathetic) or U (unsympathetic). Then **say** them with a partner: sound as kind, or as unkind, as you can.

1. Oh well, if you hadn't drunk so much, you wouldn't be feeling so bad now, would you? _____
2. Oh dear, you poor thing. _____
3. Oh yes, I know what you mean. _____
4. Oh well, it serves you right then, doesn't it? _____
5. Oh well, you've only got yourself to blame, haven't you? _____
6. That must be awful. _____

TASK 5

The language

Read the box. **Add** one more phrase to each column.

KIND

- Oh dear, you poor thing.
- That must be awful.
- I know what you mean.

NOT SO KIND

- It serves you right!
- You've only got yourself to blame.
- If you hadn't..., you wouldn't...

ADVICE

- You should / ought to + verb
- Why don't you + verb?
- If I were you, I'd + verb
- Have you tried + -ing?
- You'd better + verb

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TASK 6

Tell me your problem

Stand up. Your teacher gives you a card. Tell classmates your problem. They react, kindly or not, and give advice. Then change cards.

You ate a whole cake last night. Now you feel sick.	You have a terrible cold and a big exam tomorrow.
You stayed out until 4 a.m. and you have work at 9.	You cut your finger cooking and it won't stop bleeding.
You can't sleep: your neighbour's dog barks all night.	You've had a headache for three days.

TASK 7

You're the expert

In groups, discuss.

1. What is the best thing to do for a cold?
2. Do you go to the doctor quickly, or wait?
3. Do you believe in home remedies? Which ones?
4. Is it better to be sympathetic, or honest, when a friend is ill because of something they did?

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TASK 8

Dear Liz

In pairs: one of you runs to the letter on the wall, remembers a line, comes back and says it. Your partner writes. Change after each line.

TASK 9

Write back

In pairs, write Liz's reply: be kind, and give three pieces of advice.